

Ukraine: wartime unity will protect Zelensky even as domestic pressures mount

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Ukraine

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Wartime unity will protect Zelensky even as domestic pressures mount

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Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

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President Volodymyr Zelensky faces rising political pressure at home, with winter air strikes, corruption allegations, and renewed funding strains set to test the government through year-end.

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The wartime consensus will, however, shield Ukraine from a major political crisis while the war continues; regardless of how unpopular Zelensky becomes, impeachment, resignation, or elections remain unlikely.

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Zelensky may pay a political price for wartime strains after the Russia-Ukraine war ends, as the public will likely demand a fresh, untainted face.

Domestic pressure on Zelensky is building. Zelensky faces rising political risk at home, with winter strikes, corruption allegations, and renewed funding strains set to test his government through year-end. The presidential administration will likely spend the fall and winter managing crises, and each unpopular decision will carry a higher political cost than it would have a year ago.

Winter will remain Ukraine's greatest domestic vulnerability. The coming heating season will likely be the harshest of the war. In line with our escalation scenarios (see note [Escalation between Russia and Ukraine coming in the autumn](#)), Russia could expand strikes beyond the power grid to critical water and sanitation infrastructure. It is also likely to build on recent attacks on businesses, warehouses, and food supply networks around Kyiv to make the capital unbearable and push residents out.

The state and the public have invested heavily in resilience, but shortages of Patriot missiles will limit their effectiveness. Another risk is the perception that the government's preparations were inadequate or mishandled. Public sentiment could shift quickly if blackouts and disruptions to heating and water exceed last winter's levels, and the corruption cases would give Ukrainians a ready explanation for any failure.

Further corruption allegations will hurt Zelensky's trust ratings. With several investigations underway, new evidence will almost certainly emerge. Isolated cases involving members of parliament or less senior officials will not shift the balance of power, and presidential immunity protects Zelensky from direct charges. The greater political risk comes from cases that reach people closest to him. Claims that Zelensky participated in corruption rather than simply overlooking it could prove especially damaging.

Former Minister of Defense Mykhailo Fedorov will likely remain Zelensky's most outspoken domestic critic and continue to amplify corruption allegations indirectly. Although Fedorov's call for elections gained little traction, his narrative of corruption and mismanagement in the defense industry could gain broader support. Fedorov's seven years in the administration, combined with his public standing, give his accusations credibility.

Ukraine will again face a financing gap. The €90 billion EU loan finalized in April had appeared to settle the issue through next year. Escalation and higher military spending have reopened it, however. Finance Minister Serhii Marchenko said that \$32.6 billion of the 2027 requirement remains uncovered. The government may have to cut nonmilitary spending, including potentially winter-related expenditure, if it cannot secure more support from allies.

European governments will ultimately fill the gap, but the process will likely mirror last year's, with a period of uncertainty and possible delays. While financing Ukraine remains a top EU priority, renegotiating funding or reopening the debate over frozen Russian assets will create uncertainty. Inside Ukraine, passing bills to unlock new funding is also becoming more difficult (see note Zelensky will become more constrained as Parliament grows more assertive). Failed parliamentary votes and political trade-offs are now the norm, even during wartime.

Wartime consensus will shield Ukraine from real political instability regardless of how difficult Zelensky's position becomes. For both the public and the political class, winning the war remains the priority. Parliament will continue to fund the war even as it stalls in other areas, and domestic criticism will stop short of challenging the war effort itself. Zelensky will nonetheless have to tread carefully, because any unpopular move could trigger a wave of public discontent. That applies to how he handles a negotiated settlement—he will find it much harder to sell an unpopular deal.

Zelensky's removal is extremely unlikely. In the worst-case scenario, if the public loses trust in the president, a coalition government with a broader and more diverse power base is far more likely than impeachment or resignation. Elections are not the alternative. A parliamentary working group has ruled out voting during active combat because of logistical and safety obstacles, and Western partners, Zelensky's formal opposition, and the public alike see clear risks in destabilizing the government now.

Zelensky's post-war political career may prove to be a casualty of the crises accumulating now. His ratings will likely decline once a stable ceasefire weakens the case for national unity, and he may choose not to run in a future election rather than risk losing. That would open the field to wartime figures from within his own administration, including the head of the Office of the President, Kyrylo Budanov, while Fedorov and Valerii Zaluzhnyi, Ukraine's ambassador to the UK, would also likely run. None of these figures fully meets the underlying public demand for change. The next president could therefore be an unknown and untainted figure.

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